



LEARNING SCIENCE

Confidence is a bad signal

The feeling that you know something is produced by familiarity, not by knowing it.

One week later, in a single experiment

Study only	40% recalled, predicted 4.8 out of 7
Repeated retrieval	61% recalled, predicted 4.0 out of 7



THE POINT

*The most confident group
remembered the least*

Rereading builds familiarity. Familiarity feels exactly like knowledge, right up until somebody asks you a question.



Fluency illusion

Mistaking ease of reading for ease of recall. It is why a chapter feels mastered and a blank page feels impossible.



BY THE NUMBERS

42%

What students who reread a passage were able to recall a week later, in a separate experiment.



BY THE NUMBERS

56%

What students who put that same passage away and tried to recall it scored on the same test, a week later.



Signals worth trusting instead

1. What you wrote from memory.
2. What you got wrong yesterday.
3. What you can explain with no notes in front of you.



Stop asking whether it feels familiar

Ask what you can produce with the book shut. That answer does not flatter you.

